

5.13.2021
BUDGET HEARING Via Zoom
Notes

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Introduction 7:03

Roll: Jenny Graham, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Breanna Lungo-Koehn present
Kathy Kreatz and Mea Mustone are joining late. Melanie McLaughlin - absent

Operating budget FY22 as it pertains to academic content areas

MEV: Tonight is our third budget hearing. I look forward to proceeding with the process and thank the team for organizing this new format in a more understandable way.

David Murphy: First group of academic departments.

3 bucket areas of funding needs:

1. Personnel and staffing
2. Materials and infrastructure
3. Training and professional development

Goal: to position us where we are able to capitalize on the ESSER funding and have impact on our students and staff.

Priorities:

- Interventions to struggling students
- Strategic staffing opportunities
- Programming based initiatives
- Training and PD

Esser II: \$2.3M

Esser III: \$5.3M

For COVID Related expenses.

Each department asked for priorities of student impact and addressing repercussions of pandemic on students.

Suzanne Galusi: we want to make sure we have a remote platform for think central as well as early literacy learning tools. We have been piloting lexia and math program. We have partnered with Hill for Literacy. This week and next week, there are trainings across the district. Many program resources were brought in pre covid but others were brought in during covid and we want to continue with some of these programs.

Peter Cushing : at secondary school level, looking to restore losses: math and reading interventionists: boots on the ground. Critical need to follow through with math curriculum and el

curriculum updates. Moving forward in science with new textbooks and other materials. Looking to restore personnel with direct support to kids and support to teachers. Interventionists critical piece of moving forward.

Dr. Nicole Chiesa: ELA and Social Studies Curriculum

Thank you for all the support this year. In English and SS we have moved along quite nicely. Goal to be consistent and equitable K-12. At secondary, goal of fine tuning pacing guides and working on cultural proficiency. Middle school reading specialists are much needed at Middle School level. Evidence based reading practices and foundational skills on reading; continue to do more. We do have our reading program and will look to replace it. For this year, looking to build capacity with evidence based reading practices.

- Early literacy screener (piloting last two years; next year we need to implement this)
- Assessment tool grades 3 to 11 to identify deficits in literacy
- Social Studies: fully onto new frameworks for SS. This year spending a lot of time on civics project required by DESE. Looking to put 4 years of SS Freshman through Junior years.

Lexia was provided through Cares act as was Newsela. Found to be essential for our students.

Dave Murphy: we were put in a position due to external funding, to put new practices in place. FY22 will be a pivotal year for repairing damage done by pandemic.

Rocco Cieri: Science Curriculum

This year enabled us to use new digital resources. Textbooks in Anatomy/Physiology. Digital license for Stem Scopes with consumables. We have used less than what is needed in a typical year due to remote students. Replenishment of consumables for FOSS kits. We will require replenishment of consumables ongoing. There are few big ticket items now but may have more in future. Newsela is being used by Science teachers as well as other departments - very supportive of non-fiction reading and writing for students. Looking at extended school day programs for Science to capture the losses that at home students faced this year. We are in a position of strength due to continued investment in past years.

Dave Murphy: Extended school day may be a way of providing additional support for students. Getting some students to enroll in extended day may be more attracted to the science programs in addition to math in literacy.

Dr. Bernadette Ricciardelli: World Languages

In World Language, we are planning to introduce french in grade 6. We need to purchase text books but can use current staff. Need textbooks in French, Italian and Spanish. Grades 6.7.8 are level one of the language and need texts to ground the learning. World Languages sponsors many trips: nice to consider opportunity programs. There are areas where we will need bolstering in languages: peer tutoring program using Language Nat. Honor Society. New framework for World Language approved by DESE. We need to offer professional development

in that area as well as pd on accelerating instruction to make up for losses. If we are able to offer extended day programs, world language would be a good option.

Fine Arts: Dr. Bernadette Ricciardelli

I have filled in since last June when the previous Director retired. We looked at Art of Education and Quaver to work with remote and hybrid this year and would like to continue using them next year. We have a high school teacher who travels to Curtis Tufts. I would like to expand opportunities in art at Curtis Tufts. Long term budgetary priorities: looking at a supervisor/coordinator with Fine Arts background. I am using my management experience to work with the art and music teams to refine the program. A target area is increasing the inventory of instruments at middle school level so it is 1 to 1 in the music classroom. Funding: I am looking for what we had for the 2020 school year. For 2021 the budget was cut back. Including the line for transportation: band travel. Looking at opportunities for peer tutoring.

Kathy Kreatz now present (7:44)

Rachel Perry, Health and Physical Education:

Looking forward to unpacking new state standards when they come out early next year. Looking at budget priorities, looking for a certified adaptive physical education teacher for students with needs that cannot be traditional programs. Looking for a health teacher at the middle school to relieve the counselors of teaching duties. Goal one health teacher at each building. Goal: like to add a teacher to the Curtis Tufts School as well. Would like to create a yoga studio for students as well as for after school programs. Looking forward to purchasing equipment. Looking for after school programming opportunities such as healthy cooking and eating.

David Murphy: need for a flexible mindset. Attempting to push ourselves to think as creatively as possible. Adaptive PE priority in the district. In the short term looking for an individual to teach Adaptive PE but the long term priority is inclusive classrooms. Goal to have one certified adaptive PE teacher per building.

Paulette Van der Kloot ; I suggest questions subject by subject. ELA first. Nicole you referenced looking at Journeys, our reading program. When do you think this will happen?

Dr. Nicole Chiesa: We are looking to update Journeys our core reading program. The plan this year, we submitted a Gleem grant application that might expedite the process. If we don't get the grant, we will establish a committee with teachers to look at core reading programs that meet the needs for all students in Medford. We would then pursue a pilot process to try out different programs. Gleem grant would move the process up a year. Should we do that, the plan will occur earlier. We are looking at core programs right now and hope to do the pilot as soon as possible.

Paulette Van der Kloot: a community member mentioned in the last meeting that teachers were using picture clues. Has this been discussed?

Dr. Nicole Chiesa: Evidence based reading does not point to use of picture clues. This week we did a small group of PD with Kindergarten teachers. I don't know the exact specifics of what the person was referring to?

Paulette Van der Kloot: When will we know about the Gleem grant?

Dr. Nicole Chiesa: I am not sure - most likely until mid-summer. Work to begin in Fall of 2021. We have worked hard to partner with Hill and Dr. Orkin and hope to work with a literacy consultant to help us in the selection process.

Jenny Graham: If we get the grant, then how do we deal with the teachers having to implement new programs in two subject areas.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: This grant was such a great opportunity that we didn't want it to go by. What was stated in the subcommittee about balancing the needs of teachers. They have the intellectual capacity to learn more than one content at a time, we want to give them the opportunity to absorb it. This Gleem grant offered by the state, if in fact Medford is selected, we will have to figure out the best way to do it equitably.

Jenny Graham: I am not in support of drowning our teachers in new content. Differentiated learning is going to be harder than ever before. Pandemic hasn't impacted each student in the same way. Concerned with all the kids not getting served in the ELA program. Even if we don't get the grant, I would like to support the literacy needs to address the shortcomings facing some of our students. Unfortunately, we have a lot of curriculum deficiencies at the elementary level and would appreciate creative thinking to make it happen faster for students.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: The work with Hill and Dr. Orkin is valuable. We are supplementing Journeys with appropriate pd in evidence based instruction in literacy. We are being very creative and I appreciate all the ways Dr. Chiesa is supplementing.

Jenny Graham: The current program is deficient. When we are bolting things onto something, then it is a sign that it is not working. I am in support of whatever you need from this committee to figure out how to do this more quickly.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: We are making a deep effort to get feedback from families and teachers to assess the needs.

Dr. Nicole Chiesa: One of the biggest deficits with Journeys is the foundational skills. Phonics is moving along nicely. The assessment tool listed on the budget will give us better indicators. Lexia Core 5 does have tier 2 interventions built in. They will be beneficial as we need to meet individual needs.

Paul Ruseau: I am happy to see that there has been progress during the pandemic. I don't see any reading specialists for the high school. MEV priorities the first year, math was number one

goal. With reading, the two studies show half of the prisoners are dyslexic or have reading comprehension problems. If all of our kids are not reading to standards, I feel like we look at our ap students and focus on that. We need to focus on where there is not as much light. This is not a Medford only problem. I am surprised that the high school doesn't have reading specialists.

Dave Murphy; Reading specialists were presented as part of the elementary and middle school presentations not in the academic content budget. Through ESSER, we will be adding to our headcount but we have to prioritize the human resources should be concentrated. Coming out of years of disruption, it does appear that we are focusing these resources on the K-8 level but we need to realize where the resources can be maximized to have the greatest impact.

Dr. Nicole Chiesa: When we had our wish lists over a year ago, we did want to pull in a high school reading specialist. My priority is to make sure we get the ms reading specialists we lost. We do have literacy challenge classes for tier two students who show gaps in reading, writing, and comprehension. It is not taught by a reading specialist but it is taught by a humanities teacher. It is a priority of mine to support level two as well as level three students at the high school.

Paul Ruseau: If we could figure out how to have reading specialists, that would be wonderful. I see 15 to 20% of the population are dyslexic. I am pretty sure that 15 to 20% of our students are not diagnosed with dyslexia. Parents of certain characteristics get IEPs more than parents of students with other characteristics. The world demands strong literacy skills.

Dr. Nicole Chiesa: The assessment tool grades 3 to 11 that we are looking to bring next year will be used to identify students with these gaps. Those types of assessments/tools are needed to help students who might not have a disability but have gaps we need to close.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: You mentioned 3 to 11 assessment tools - what about K-2?

Dr. Nicole Chiesa: K-2 will be tested using the Early Literacy Screener (being used right now - conducted three times per year and will be used to determine summer intervention goals). Assessment will also be used for math and science grades 3 - 11.

Dave Murphy: Because of the absence of reliable data, we have to think creatively. It is a critical priority regardless of price.

Questions on Science

Paulette Van der Kloot: You mentioned Newsela for Science? Are we not using it yet? How expensive is it?

Rocco Cieri: We are moving forward with it this year.

Dave Murphy: It was funded through Cares Act funding and is a modest cost. It will be used for Science.

Paul Ruseau: When we went with the new Foss program, we talked a lot about it. Maybe next year, when we have to deal with renewables, we just automatically build it in. We can consider it a necessity. If we don't buy the consumables, the program ceases to function.

Dave Murphy; This is a fixed cost. It is a key priority we want to commit to.

Questions on Health and PE:

Paul Ruseau: we are not going to end up with an additional pe teacher in each building but in FY 22 we will add a position to make sure we have an adaptive teacher on staff?

Dave Murphy: We will use that person to deliver PD: train the trainer model and hopefully train a specialized adaptive teacher in each bldg. Will have bargaining implications.

Kathy Kreatz: Before COVID, I toured the site that was supposed to be the yoga studio and spin studio. I would be excited to see if we could get that going. I receive messages from parents that their students are not getting enough exercise. Would be nice to have extra facilities for the students. Hopefully we can do this in the long term.

Rachel Perry: We are definitely pursuing this with the Vocational students. Central is supporting this as well.

Dave Murphy: Some items might end up on capital budget. It is not likely to end up on the operating budget.

Paul Ruseau: Health teacher in the Michigan Model?

Dave Murphy: We are building licenses into our budgetary model.

Paul Ruseau: We need to find the right person comfortable teaching Sex Education so that it is not taught in a harmful way.

Music Questions

Paulette Van der Kloot: I am concerned about a whole group of students missing fourth and fifth grade string programs. This is the feeder program for the band and orchestra. I am curious as to how we will deal with that. Will Violin be offered in Middle School? It is crucial for them to have that start in order to have middle school music opportunities.

Bernadette Ricciardelli: DESE put out strict guidance about use of instruments. We have had numerous discussions in the department about this. Thanks to Haley Rello and Sophia Chang. We just sent an email this morning reaching out to parents about instruments. We are also offering classroom presentations. We are encouraging parents to get their children involved in band and orchestra. We are also reaching out to incoming 4th and 5th grade parents to try to bolster the program. I specifically mentioned ukulele and guitar but we are aware of the necessary outreach.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Will fifth graders be able to play violin?

Bernadette Ricciardelli: Yes. We have flexibility with our staff. All music staff are K-12. We need to address the demand and then position the staff to deal with the lessons.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Will we need more violins next year? There may be 5th graders who didn't get the opportunity in 4th grade. Do we have the capacity?

Bernadette Ricciardelli: Sophia Chang has been inventorying the violin supply. We may need to bolster that.

David Murphy : This is a concrete example of how we don't want their academic career to be limited by the 2020-21 school year. Every budgetary priority needs to be looked at in this way. We will work on cultivating the interest and supplying the instruments.

Marice Edouard-Vincent: Mr. Murphy addressed the district's position but we are prioritizing the arts to make sure our fine arts programming is aligned k-12. I thank her for her leadership and for the great work in the fine arts department. I know we are operating differently right now but good things are happening. If additional instruments are needed, we are prepared to provide them.

Paul Ruseau: Arts overlooked in the extended day programming?

Dave Murphy: Even if we are to build an extended day program, we will include arts and music to be included as they will attract more students.

Paul Ruseau: Should we get all the instruments we could possibly need and use ESSER funding. If we have a nickel left, that will be a sad day. The thing of buying extra is you stick them in the store room. They don't go bad.

Jenny Graham : I would like to think of fine arts spending the same way as athletics. If we subsidize athletic transportation and equipment, we should do the same for fine arts programs. In last year's budget, we had a conversation about office supplies for schools and that didn't seem defensible because of the different numbers of people in each building. Understanding what constitutes a rational budget - this stands out for me.

World Language questions:

Paulette Van der Kloot: \$49K for introduction for French in grade 6?

Dr. Bernadette Ricciardelli: That amount is for all three grades and languages in Middle School.

Dr. Bernadette Ricciardelli: High school languages use more small readers. Less text book based. Grade nine does have a few level one classrooms that would require textbooks but they are not that old.

Paulette Van der Kloot: We no longer have an Italian program at the elementary level. One thing about the Italian program is it broadened the horizons of elementary school students. I am wondering how we are going to incorporate that type of learning into our curriculum with that being gone.

Dr. Bernadette Ricciardelli : As for the 5th prep, it has been identified that there are needs elsewhere that Suzanne Galusi is addressing. Elementary Social Studies does address the globalization topic. Middle school has programs very directly related to this concept. Yes we lose the cultural piece with the loss of the Italian program but hope to gain new things with the fifth prep.

Suzanne Galusi: There is a void with that loss but we are dealing with the current need of social emotional and executive functioning skills that were lost during the pandemic. The Italian program didn't service every student in the building but this fifth prep will help every student. The cultural component is part of the English Language Arts/Social Studies as well as the Cultural Proficiency component we are working on with teachers.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Who will be teaching this class?

Suzanne Galusi: We are hiring for this new position.

Dave Murphy: We are saving some things for next week. This special class will be multidisciplinary.

Jenny Graham: Motion to accept the recommendations outlined tonight across all categories for final review on May 19.

Seconded by Paulette Van der Kloot .

Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot , Breanna Lungo-Koehn :
Five yes; two no. Motion passes.

Paul Ruseau: I believe that the last hearing should not be included with the hearing for approval. Combining the two doesn't give enough time to review.

Kathy Kreatz: I agree - too much in one meeting. I recommend a separate meeting date for the public hearing.

Jenny Graham: My question is last year we had posting requirements in the newspaper?

David Murphy : The vast majority of school committees don't take the second vote. We will call the newspaper and post it appropriately.

Jenny Graham: I agree having the public hearing and the vote on what will get sent to the mayor's office as a request should be separate. I would like to get it done in the month of May.

Dave Murphy: We will send proposed dates tomorrow and get it on the calendar.

Paul Ruseau : Does the statute say we must post for the first vote or the second vote?

Dave Murphy: It doesn't specify. It is fine either way. I think it makes sense to open it up to the public. You will have time to entertain that over the next month.

Motion to adjourn: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot , Breanna Lungo-Koehn :

Five yes; two no. Motion passes. Meeting Adjourned 9:06